

A door to the dharma

for my sister

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“Can you teach me how to meditate,” you ask.

Why meditate?	3
How to meditate?	4
What makes you not a Buddhist?	5

Why meditate?

You say you want to meditate. Why is that? To calm your mind? To become a better person? To become ‘enlightened’? There is no single, right answer to this question. Yet, this question is always asked when starting with meditation. I have been taught that before you start to meditate, you need to have a clear intention.

In the Chan tradition, we say this at the beginning:¹

I vow to deliver innumerable sentient beings.
I vow to cut off endless vexations.
I vow to master limitless approaches to Dharma.
I vow to attain supreme buddhahood.

I start with that, followed by the following aspiration of Gampopa which I learned in the Kagyu tradition:²

Grant your blessing³ so that the mind of myself and all beings may be one with the dharma.
Grant your blessing so that the dharma may progress along the path.
Grant your blessing so that the path may clarify confusion.
Grant your blessing so that confusion may dawn as wisdom.

But be aware, while having aspirations and inspirations is useful in sustaining a practice, don’t strive or hope for anything.

You came to this retreat in hopes of improving your practice and clearing your minds through meditation. If you had greater expectations, perhaps I discouraged you when I said that meditating has nothing to do with becoming enlightened. One of you wondered what the point of meditating is, if it does not lead to enlightenment. The answer is that while meditation does not lead to enlightenment, if you do not meditate you will never be enlightened.⁴

¹ Master Sheng-Yen, Illuminating Silence.

² Gampopa, Ornament of Precious Liberation.

³ jin gyi lab in Tibetan is usually translated as ‘blessing’, which may be misleading some. The Tibetan term literally means to transform, to uplift, to brighten. ‘Grant your inspiration’ may have better a better connotation to Western ears. See [common misunderstandings about tantra](#).

⁴ Master Shen-Yen, [commentary on Nitou’s Song of Mind](#).

How to meditate?

What makes you not a Buddhist?

When the Buddha taught the Four Noble Truths he repeated them three times, expanding them successively. First he said, “There is suffering in this world. There are causes of this suffering. There is cessation of suffering, and there are ways to reach the cessation of suffering.” Then he said, “There is suffering in this world, one has to understand it. There are causes of this suffering, and one has to eliminate them. There is cessation of suffering, and one has to attain it. There are ways to reach the cessation of suffering, and one has to work upon them.” The third time he said, “There is suffering in this world, one has to understand it, but actually there is nothing to understand. There are causes of this suffering, and one has to eliminate them, but actually there is nothing to eliminate. There is cessation of suffering, and one has to attain it, but actually there is nothing to attain. There are ways to reach the cessation of suffering, and one has to work upon them, but actually there is nothing to work upon.” This was the first teaching of the Buddha, which he gave at Sarnath to his first five disciples: Kaundinya, Bhaddiya, Vappa, Mahanama, and Asvajit.⁵

⁵ Ringu Tulku, *Daring Steps Toward Fearlessness: the Three Vehicles of Buddhism* (p. 22).